

Say No with Confidence

Phrase Bank & Tone Tips for the Workplace

Direct Boundary Phrases

Use when you need clarity and confidence.

- *“Sorry I can’t take this on right now.”*
 - *“I’m currently at capacity and wouldn’t be able to give this the attention it deserves.”*
 - *“I won’t be able to help with that this time.”*
 - *“That’s not something I can commit to at the moment.”*
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2. Softened Boundary Phrases

Use when tone or relationship dynamics call for added care.

- *“I’d love to help, but I need to say no this time.”*
 - *“I want to support you, but I’m stretched too thin right now.”*
 - *“I’m really honoured you asked—unfortunately I have to pass this time.”*
 - *“I’m trying to be more mindful about what I take on, so I’ll have to say no to this.”*
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3. Saying Yes With Limits

Use when you want to support but set clear expectations.

- *“Yes, I can help—but I’ll need to keep it short.”*
- *“I can do this, but not until next week. Will that still work?”*
- *“I can take this on if something else can come off my plate.”*
- *“Yes, with one condition: I’ll need support from [person/resource].”*

4. Tone Tips Based on Audience

To a Manager

- Use clarity and professionalism.
- Soften with appreciation:
"Thanks for thinking of me—right now I'm not able to give this the focus it needs."

To a Peer

- Use honesty and shared accountability:
"I know we're both juggling a lot. I don't have the bandwidth for this right now."

To a Direct Report

- Balance care and clarity:
"I appreciate you asking, but I need you to check with [X] instead."

Glossary:

- **Tight on time:** I don't have enough time available.
- **Drop from my plate:** Remove a responsibility.
- **Offline:** Outside this meeting or conversation.
- **Extra work:** Additional tasks beyond regular responsibilities.
- **Bandwidth:** The time, energy, or mental capacity someone has available to take on more work.
- **Stretched too thin (workplace meaning):** Having too many responsibilities or tasks, making it hard to do any of them well
- **Juggling:** Managing multiple tasks, roles, or responsibilities at the same time—often with difficulty.